By the late 1950s, both Moscow and Washington regarded Beijing as provocative and destabilizing to the international system. The two superpowers had gradually begun to construct Cold War norms and limits between the two blocs. China on the other hand had a more radical view: it wanted to challenge the US and Western powers in the name of socialism. The USSR and the US were warming to India at the same time. By the early 1960s, however, there were signs of a huge geopolitical shift, with India coming closer to the Soviets, and the Chinese and Americans reaching out to each other.

The USSR tilts to India

As China's relations with India deteriorated in the late 1950s, peaking in the Longju clash in August 1959, it wanted a clear sign from the Soviets that they sided politically and diplomatically with their communist ally in the border quarrel. It did not expect or want Moscow's military backing. It had repelled the US-led UN force in Korea with very little help from Moscow, and Indian military power was hardly in the same league as the international coalition. China did, however, expect the communist world to stand politically together against a bourgeois-minded India.

Responding to Beijing, Moscow urged compromise and moderation with Delhi. Then, in September 1959, the Soviets suddenly and very publicly declared neutrality in the India–China conflict. Where Stalin had been supportive of China, even urging Mao to deal with the Tibetan problem by settling Han Chinese populations in the region, Khrushchev expressed unhappiness.[4] At a seven-hour meeting with Mao in October 1959, he did some plain-speaking on the intensifying India–China conflict. Khrushchev defended Nehru, blamed China for the flight of the Dalai Lama to India earlier that year (Beijing's repression, in his view, being the cause), and criticized the attack on Indian troops at Longju. China's replies were defensive, rejecting Khrushchev's finger-pointing over Tibet and the Longju incident. The latter, Mao claimed, had occurred without permission of the